capture devices make use of this interface to transfer video to the hard drive.

Only Gigabyte's GA-8I915GV and GA-8I1000G came equipped with Gigabit LAN.

USB ports were also standard accessories on all the motherboards. The Gigabyte GA-8IG1000, HIS FA61 and HIS M48-F3 had only two USB ports, whereas the others had four.

Most boards came with two or three PCI slots. Since video, sound and LAN come onboard, the necessity to add PCI cards for these functions has been eliminated. Hence, a lower number of PCI card slots will not be much of an issue, as there are only a few types of add-on cards that you might want—such as TV tuner cards.

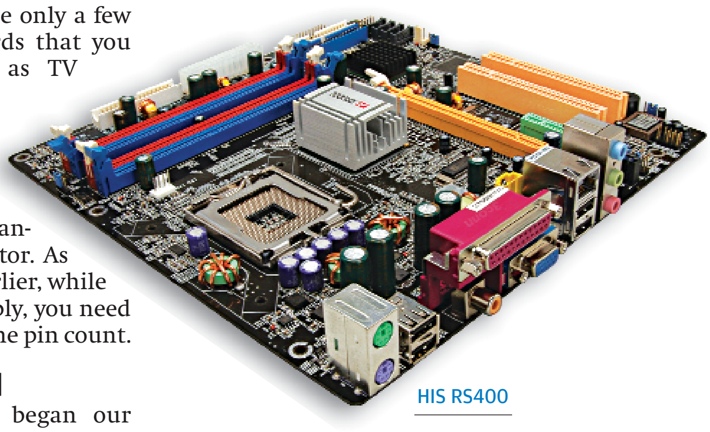
Almost half the boards had a 24-pin power connector. The others had the standard 20 pin connector. As we've mentioned earlier, while buying a power supply, you need to be careful about the pin count.

How They Fared

As with AMD, we began our benchmarking by seeing how the boards would fare on the graphics and gaming front. Even though this might not be what the targeted user might use the boards for, it is still a good way to test the speed and system performance.

The motherboard that scored the highest in our Serious Sam test was the Foxconn 915PLAE-8S. This board scored a mammoth 152 and 133.1 fps in the 640 x 480 and 800 x 600 resolutions. However, it must be pointed out that this board lacked an onboard graphics solution, so we'd used an nVidia GeForce FX6200 PCIE card, which led to a substantial increase in scores.

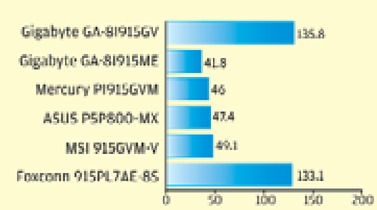
The HIS RS400 came in second with 57.8 and 40.5, and was followed by the Gigabyte 8TRS 350MT, which logged a commendable 54.6 and beat the HIS RS400 in the 800 x 600 scores by logging 47.5.



HIS RS400

The worst performer here was the MSI RS 350M-ILSR. This ATi RS350-based socket 478 motherboard logged a measly 25 and 21.9 fps, and you should steer clear of it if you have even the remotest chance of running an application that is even slightly graphics-intensive.

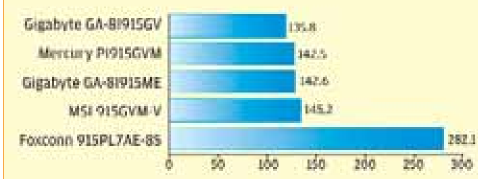
Serious Sam (800x600)



FPS score, higher is better

We then put the boards through a few demos of Quake 3 Arena, and the picture changed slightly—but not at the top. That was ruled completely by the Foxconn 915PL7AE-8S, which logged a humongous 370.7 and 282.1, but of course, as we've mentioned before, it had a graphics card to help it with the games! The second-placed board here was the Gigabyte 8TRS 350MT, which logged 178.5 and 131.7 for the above-mentioned resolutions, and barely edged out the newer LAG775 socket HIS RS400 which clocked 176.9 and 112.9 fps.

Quake III (800x600)



FPS score, higher is better

The board that did miserably here was the MSI PM8M2-V. This Via-based board scored really bad—52.3 and 31.5. Of course, 31.5 is very playable, but it is not acceptable considering the kind of scores the other boards were logging.

Another board that performed beautifully was the Mercury PI915GVM. The board logged a commendable 157.4 and 142.5 fps, and came in fourth.

The real graphics benchmark, 3DMark 2001 SE, gave us rather surprising results.

The board that lost out hugely here was the HIS FA61, which logged a mere 1480—which was quite surprising, as the board was based on the new Via P4M800 chipset and is an LGA 775 socket.

Its more powerful and newer cousin, the HIS RS400, logged an impressive 5951 3Dmarks, and stood first by a fair margin over the second-fastest board, the Asus P5P800-MX, which clocked 5762.

The third-fastest was the MSI 915GVM. It scored 5571 3DMarks, and just barely edged out the Mercury PI915GVM, which came in fourth with a score of 5549.